

FORMS OF COMMUNICATION: VERBAL AND NONVERBAL

The communication process can take any of the four forms—verbal and nonverbal. Both forms usually operate together in the majority of messages you send and receive. Spoken or oral and written are both forms of verbal communication while nonverbal consists of visual and audio-visual.

VERBAL COMMUNICATION

1. Oral
2. Written
3. Visual
4. Audio visual

Types of verbal communication

1. Face to face communication: involves the speaker and the listener interacting face to face such as in dyadic, small group or public speaking.
2. Telephone conversation: involve two people interacting by use of telephone though it is possible for a small group by means of teleconferencing.
3. The radio: makes it possible to speak to a large number of people at the same time.
4. Written communication: involves use of written forms of communication such as letters, memos, reports, circulars, etc.

Spoken and Written Communication

Oral communication is more natural and immediate; we speak to communicate in natural and informal situations. We also speak in formal and official situations such as making a presentation or taking an interview when the target audience is present. Written communication has to be used when the other person is not present and is not available on the telephone. Long and complex messages are best conveyed in writing.

Attributes/Features of Spoken and Written Communication

Oral and written communications have different attributes which have to be taken into account in choosing which one to use in a particular situation.

(i) **Speed:** Written communication is slower in preparation, in conveyance and in reception; it takes more time to draft, type, dispatch, and to receive and read a letter than it takes to speak, and to hear, listen to, and understand an oral message. Feedback is also slower in written communication.

(ii) **Record:** Written communication serves as a record and can be used for future reference. It is a documentary proof, and can be used as legal evidence. Oral communication may be taped for later ' reference, but the

Authenticity of the voice can be questioned; moreover, tapes can be edited and the message distorted. Written records and documents are more reliable and acceptable.

(iii) **Precision and accuracy:** Written communication is more precise and accurate than oral. Choice of precise words is possible in written communication because the writer has the time to look for suitable words and phrases, and to revise the draft, if necessary. Accuracy is necessary in written communication because the receiver is not present to ask for clarification. In oral communication, it is not always possible to be so precise in the choice of words. There is also no time to seek and consider words while speaking; however, the receiver can seek clarification on the spot. Besides, oral communication has the support of vocal ' tone and gestures and expressions which enrich the meaning of the words.

(iv) **Length:** A written message is usually shorter than an oral communication. The situation of oral communication requires some preliminary and closing remarks, while for written messages there are standard formats for opening and closing which can keep the message short.

(vi) **Expense:** Written communication requires stationery, preparation, and transmission, all of which cost money. Oral communication can also cost a great deal since it requires simultaneous presence and attention of the two parties, and getting together costs money. Costs will depend on the availability of the required person(s) at the particular place.

(vii) **Body Language:** Oral communication is supported by the speaker's body language and paralanguage. The speaker can control the style of delivery, giving meaning to words and sentences by voice inflexion and facial expressions and gestures. Written communication is separated from the writer's bodily presence and is more in the control of the reader. The reader can give to the words the sound, inflexion and stress as he chooses; and this may be affected by the reader's mood and state of mind at the time of reading.

(viii) **Feedback:** Oral communication allows immediate feedback; the listener's face gives some feedback and the speaker can modify the message on the spot. Clarifications can be sought and given at once. A conversation can be brought to a satisfactory conclusion by continuous exchange of ideas and views. In written communication the feedback is delayed; the reader's facial expressions cannot be seen by the writer; the reader's response is known to the writer only when the reader replies. The reader may give a cautious and guarded reply without letting the other see the really felt reaction.

(ix) **Formality:** Spoken language tends to be less formal than written language. When a language is spoken, there are abbreviations and dropping of some sounds, as in *can't, won't, don't, I'll, we'll*. The vocabulary used in written

English is also more formal than in spoken English. Spoken English requires learning correct pronunciation English spelling does not always indicate how the word is pronounced. We have to learn correct pronunciation so that we can communicate with people in other parts of the world.

Importance of verbal communication

(i) **Speed:** Oral communication is fast with immediate feedback.

(ii) **Record:** Written communication serves as a record and can be used for future reference. It is a documentary proof, and can be used as legal evidence. Written records and documents are more reliable and acceptable.

(iii) **Precision and accuracy:** Written communication is precise and accurate. Choice of precise words is possible in written communication because the writer has the time to look for suitable words and phrases, and to revise the draft, if necessary. Accuracy is

necessary in written communication because the receiver is not present to ask for clarification.

(iv)Length: A written message is usually shorter than an oral communication. There are standard formats for opening and closing which can keep the message short

(v) Body Language: Oral communication is supported by the speaker's body language and paralanguage which enrich meaning.

(vi)Feedback: Oral communication allows immediate feedback; the listener's face gives some feedback and the speaker can modify the message on the spot. Clarifications can be sought and given at once. A conversation can be brought to a satisfactory conclusion by continuous exchange of ideas and views.

(vii) Formality: verbal communication allow for choice between being formal or informal. Spoken language tends to be less formal than written language. The vocabulary used in written English is also more formal than in spoken English.

NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Nonverbal communication is all communication that is not spoken or written. Nonverbal communication has a great impact and influence on the receiver's decoding or interpretation of any message.

Types of nonverbal communication

1. Body Movement (body language)

The study of body movement is known as **kinesics** and it deals with all the ways people use their bodies to communicate or enhance their verbal communication. Body movement includes posture, gestures, facial expressions, and eye contact.

Posture—the way you position and move your body—can communicate a great deal about you. For example, leaning toward or leaning away from someone in conversation can convey your degree of interest, attentiveness, or involvement. Turning your back or standing to leave can convey a lack of interest or signal the end to the conversation.

Gestures are any movement of the hands, fingers, or arms. Open arms can signify honesty and openness.

Facial expressions are the arrangement of facial muscles to communicate messages. They include the mouth, cheeks, eyes, eyelids, eyebrows, forehead, nose, and chin. The face is probably the most observed part of the body when we communicate with others, and this is not without reason. Our face usually communicates our internal, emotional experience.

Eye contact can also communicate several different types of messages. Direct eye contact in our culture can communicate involvement, intimidation, and intimacy. A diverted or downcast gaze communicates a different message. Our eyes can also communicate dominance and submission. We can “stare someone down” with a prolonged gaze that is not returned by the other person, or we can avoid or break eye contact when talking with a superior, such as a boss or supervisor.

2. Paralanguage

Paralanguage is how we speak. Paralanguage includes pitch, volume, rate, and quality. **Pitch** refers to the highness or lowness of our voice. The pitch of our voice is primarily determined by the physical length and thickness of our vocal chords, but it can rise if we are frightened, anxious, or excited, and it can lower if we are attempting to sound more powerful or authoritative.

Volume refers to the relative softness or loudness of our voice. We often speak in a characteristic volume; some individuals talk loudly, whereas others talk in almost a whisper. We can also adjust our volume to meet the requirements of the communication setting we are in. In a noisy, crowded room we raise our volume and speak above the other voices, whereas during a movie or quiet dinner we lower our voice.

Rate is how fast or slow we speak. People tend to have their own personal rate of speech. Some speak fast, others slow. We tend to increase our rate of speech when we’re excited, frightened, or nervous, and we tend to decrease our rate of speech when we’re uncertain, thoughtful, and sad.

Quality refers to the overall sound of our voice. Each human voice has a distinctive tone. The quality of one's voice may be characterized as soothing, harsh, strident, or calm. We each have a distinctive quality to the way we sound. Can you recall your mother's voice? Your father's voice? Your best friend's voice? Often, when answering the telephone, we immediately recognize the caller by his or her voice quality.

3. Personal Presentation

Our **clothing** is one of the most obvious and public displays of who we are and what we want to communicate to others. The primary consideration is popularity, attractiveness, and status. We can create a variety of public images simply by the clothing we wear.

Our **grooming** can also reflect and communicate messages to the world. The length and style of our hair, bathing routines, makeup, cologne and perfume, finger and toenail painting (even for men these days), and many other grooming habits communicate a great deal about who we are and how we want to be perceived.

Touching is the most intimate form of nonverbal communication behaviour. Touching behaviour, or **haptics**, as it is called by social scientists, includes all behaviour that involves the skin. Primarily, touching behaviour deals with our hands and how we use them to communicate.

4. Proxemics

Proxemics, the study of our use of space, and was first introduced by anthropologist Edward Hall in his book *The Hidden Dimension*. By observing conversations between people, Hall discovered that our personal space could be broken down into four zones or distances:

♦ **Intimate distance** (0 to 18 inches) is reserved for intimate activities include making love, holding intimate or confidential conversations, hugging, kissing, and snuggling. This is often referred to as our

“personal bubble.” Only our most intimate relationships are permitted into this area. If an uninvited person invades our personal bubble, whether it's a stranger sitting next to us on an empty bench or a person getting too close for comfort during a conversation, we usually move away slightly to maintain our intimate distance.

♦ **Personal distance** (18 inches to 4 feet) is used for most conversations with family, friends, and most acquaintances.

♦ **Social distance** (4 to 12 feet) is the distance we feel most comfortable with transacting business, sitting during committee meetings, and interacting with the hotel clerk, the supermarket cashier, or the police officer giving us a ticket.

♦ **Public distance** (12 to 25 feet) is used for public ceremonies, speeches, large group meetings, and class lectures. If the distance between people is greater than 25 feet, communication is often limited to shouting and exaggerated nonverbal gestures.

The distance of your personal space changes depending on the setting, the people involved, and how you are feeling at the moment. Cultural factors also play an important role in determining proxemic distancing and personal comfort.

5. Sign language

Sign language is a form of non-verbal communication commonly used for the hearing impaired. It involves the use of hands to make symbolic gestures which have specific meanings. Sign language is taught in formal learning institutions for communication with the hearing impaired such as the use of braille. Communicating using sign language for the visually impaired may take the form of:

- Finger spelling,
- Signing Exact English (SEE),
- Kenya Sign Language (KSL)

NB: find out what the three concepts entail.

Importance of nonverbal communication

(a) Non-verbal methods have almost instant effect because of quicker grasp by the receiver. Speed in conveyance and response makes non-verbal methods extremely useful in critical situations like traffic signs and signals.

(b) Visual non-verbal methods aid verbal communication; maps, charts and graphs are necessary for conveying information or plans related to geography, locations, data, and most of the sciences. A large amount of complex data can be presented in a compact form; one page can convey information that would need several pages of words. It makes information available conveniently, at a glance for comparisons.

(c) Response to visuals and plain sounds is more powerful than to language. A cry of agony arouses stronger response than a sad story; a film is more effective than a written story. TV news is more interesting than on radio.

(d) It is the best method to convey information to illiterate people. Containers of poisons are marked with a skull and cross-bones as a warning; illiterate drivers manage with the non-verbal traffic signals. Films are used to explain processes to people who may not follow oral explanations easily. Non-verbal communication can overcome the barrier of language.

(e) Sign language helps the hearing impaired to communicate, learn and be able to work like any other physically normal persons.

FUNCTIONS OF NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

- a) Message reinforcement or complementation of verbal messages, for example, a warm welcome and a firm handshake.
- b) Negation of the verbal message.
- c) Message substitution, i.e. using nonverbal without verbal communication such as pointing.
- d) Message accentuation/intensification i.e. smiling as you say, "It is nice to meet you."
- e) Message regulation, i.e. lowering the voice to mark the end of a turn or eye contact to nominate the next speaker.